

Explain a Problem You Are Facing at Work

Explain

OREO

Problem Report

Name: _____ Date: _____

SLIDE 02 Today's goal

By the end of this lesson, I can:

Tell your manager where you are stuck, why, what it affects and what you need, and answer a simple follow-up question.

- WHO** You work in the accounts team of a small company in Johor Bahru. Every week you pay the suppliers online.
- SITUATION** It is Wednesday morning. Your bank security token is broken, and the bank needs three working days to send a new one: it comes on Monday. Six suppliers are waiting for RM8,400 in total.
- NEED** The paper supplier needs RM1,200 by Friday, or they stop your next delivery. The other five can wait until Monday. Mr. Tan has a login too. He has two minutes between meetings.
- GOAL** Tell Mr. Tan where you are stuck, why, what it affects and what you need from him. Then answer his questions.
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SLIDE 03 Try it first

Mr. Tan asks: "You look worried. Is something wrong with the supplier payments?" Say something for 30 seconds. Then note what you said.

SLIDE 04 A good message

Mei Ling's answer. Mark where each part starts.

Mr. Tan, I'm stuck on the supplier payments. At the moment I can't log in to our bank account. This is because my security token is broken, and the bank needs three working days to send a new one. It comes on Monday. So six suppliers are still waiting for RM8,400. For example, the paper supplier needs RM1,200 by Friday, or they stop our next delivery. What I need is your help. Can you pay the paper supplier from your login today? The other five can wait until Monday. Did I explain that clearly?

O

PROBLEM

R

CAUSE

E

EFFECT

O

WHAT I NEED

SLIDE 05 Organise it

Kumar tells Mr. Tan about a problem. Put his sentences in order: Problem → Cause → Effect → What I need.

☐

The reason is that we are still waiting for the new towel prices from the factory.

☐

I'm stuck on the quotation for our new hotel customer.

☐

That's why the hotel is still waiting. They want 300 towels, and they need our price by 12 tomorrow.

☐

What I need is your help. Can you call the factory manager today?

Write the letter: **O** = Problem · **R** = Cause · **E** = Effect · **O** = What I need

SLIDE 06 Useful language

Tick the expressions you used today.

SAY WHERE YOU ARE STUCK

☐ I'm stuck on ...

☐ The problem is that ...

☐ At the moment I can't ...

GIVE THE CAUSE

☐ This is because ...

☐ The reason is that ...

☐ It's happening because ...

SAY THE EFFECT

☐ So ...

☐ That's why ...

☐ This means that ...

☐ For example, ...

SAY WHAT YOU NEED

☐ What I need is ...

☐ Can you ...?

☐ I need your OK to ...

CHECK UNDERSTANDING

☐ Did I explain that clearly?

☐ Shall I say that again?

☐ Do you have any questions?

☐ Sorry, can you say that again?

SLIDE 07 Connect the ideas

Choose the connector and write the new sentence.

1. I can't log in to the bank account. [**because** / **for example**, / **so**] My security token is broken.

2. The token is broken. [**so** / **because** / **but**] Six suppliers are still waiting.

3. Five suppliers can wait until Monday. [**because** / **so** / **but**] The paper supplier needs the money by Friday.

4. We don't pay the paper supplier by Friday. [**For example**, / **because** / **If ...**] They stop our next delivery.

SLIDE 08 Time control

Circle the right form. Why?

1. My security token _____ work any more. (A fact about now)

☐ don't

☐ isn't

☐ doesn't

2. Six suppliers _____ for their money. (Happening now, not finished)

☐ is wait

☐ waiting

☐ are waiting

3. I _____ pay them from my login. (What you cannot do now)

☐ can't to

☐ not can

☐ can't

4. If the new token _____ on Monday, I can pay the other five suppliers. (A condition)

☐ comes

☐ coming

☐ come

SLIDE 09 Present Continuous · can't · basic if

A problem report is about now: what is happening, what you can't do, and what happens if nothing changes.

Six suppliers **are still waiting**.

I **'m waiting** for the new token.

I **can't** log in to the bank account.

If we **don't pay** by Friday, they **stop** the delivery.

SLIDE 10 Build your message

Fill each part with your own idea. You will use the same parts in the task.

O

PROBLEM

I'm stuck on ... At the moment I can't ...

R

CAUSE

This is because ...

E

EFFECT

So ... For example, ...

O

WHAT I NEED

What I need is ... Can you ...? Did I explain that clearly?

SLIDE 11 Problem Report

The speaker reports a problem from a mixed-up card. The manager cannot see the card and fills a Problem Report note: problem, cause, effect, what is needed.

1. Quiet minute: mark each fact on your card P, C, E or N. Round 1 (3:00): report problem → cause → effect → need.
2. Manager: read the listener card at the seat. Fill the note, numbered 1–4 as you hear it. Read back, ask one question.
3. Round 2 (2:00): managers move one seat. Same card, new manager, a shorter report.
4. Round 3 (2:00): new manager. Speakers turn workbook and card over and speak without reading. Then swap roles.

Card 1 · The delivery van

Card 2 · The meeting room

Card 3 · The online orders

Card 4 · The office internet

Problem Report

	ROUND 1	ROUND 2	ROUND 3
Problem			
Cause			
Effect + example			
What they need			

My partner's question or concern, and what I answered:

SLIDE 12 Respond

Mr. Tan asks. Write a short answer to one of these.

1. Who do I need to pay today, and how much?
2. Why can't the paper supplier wait until Monday?
3. What about the other five suppliers?

Start with: **The paper supplier needs ... · Because ... · They can ...**

SLIDE 13 Transfer

You rent a condo unit in JB. The kitchen sink is leaking because a pipe under it is cracked. The cabinet is wet every morning, and yesterday the water reached the floor. You want the owner to send a plumber this week. Phone the owner: explain the problem and say what you need.

I'm calling about ... · This is because ... · So ... For example, ... · What I need is ...

SLIDE 14 Did I do it?

Be honest. Tick what you did in the task.

☐ Says where they are stuck and gives the cause.

☐ Says what the problem affects, with one example (a number, a person or a day).

☐ Says clearly what they need from the listener.

SLIDE 15 Feedback: how can I improve?

Circle one number for each area. 1 = I need help · 2 = OK · 3 = Good

Problem and cause

☐ 1

☐ 2

☐ 3

Effect and example

☐ 1

☐ 2

☐ 3

Saying what I need

☐ 1

☐ 2

☐ 3

Useful expressions

☐ 1

☐ 2

☐ 3

Confidence

☐ 1

☐ 2

☐ 3

My improvement action: Next time, I will _____.

WE BELIEVE IN THE POWER OF PRACTICAL SPEAKING TO INSPIRE CONFIDENCE

After class: open the After class review

SLIDE 11 **Listener cards: fold or cut**

Only the listener looks at a card. It says what to find out and write in the note.

Card 1 • The delivery van

You are Mr. Tan. Write four lines: problem, cause, effect (with one example), what they need. Ask about a line that is empty or not clear. If your note is full, ask: "When is it back?"

Card 2 • The meeting room

You are Mr. Tan. Write four lines: problem, cause, effect (with one example), what they need. Ask about a line that is empty or not clear. If your note is full, ask: "How much is it?"

Card 3 • The online orders

You are Mr. Tan. Write four lines: problem, cause, effect (with one example), what they need. Ask about a line that is empty or not clear. If your note is full, ask: "How long do you need them?"

Card 4 • The office internet

You are Mr. Tan. Write four lines: problem, cause, effect (with one example), what they need. Ask about a line that is empty or not clear. If your note is full, ask: "When can they fix it?"

SLIDE 11 **Speaker cards: fold or cut**

Only the speaker looks at a card. The listener keeps this page folded.

Card 1 · The delivery van

A café in Skudai needs 20 boxes by Thursday · The workshop needs 2 more days · You can't do this week's deliveries · The van's gearbox is broken · You want to rent a van for 2 days (RM180 a day) · 14 deliveries are waiting

Card 2 · The meeting room

8 customers visit us on Friday at 10 · The room is 33 degrees by 10 a.m. · The aircon compressor is broken; the part comes next week · You can't use the meeting room · You want a meeting room at the hotel next door (RM250)

Card 3 · The online orders

You want 2 part-time packers for 3 days (RM80 a day each) · 60 orders are waiting · You can't send today's orders on time · 3 bad reviews today · 2 of our 4 packers are on medical leave until Monday · The other 2 pack all day

Card 4 · The office internet

A customer needs our price list by 3 p.m. today · The internet company comes on Friday · You can't send emails from the office · The cable outside is damaged · You want a mobile Wi-Fi device today (RM150) · 9 emails are waiting